may I have this dance?

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/77904156.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

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Canon Universe, Pre-Canon, Dancing, Pining, Teenagers, POV Catra (She-Ra), SPOP Creative Flex (She-Ra), SPOP Thank you She-Ra (She-Ra)

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Part 5 of Outside of the War - She-ra canon stories

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by n7punk

Summary

Day-to-day training in the Horde may be focused around battle, but sometimes they come up with ways to switch it up and teach skills that are applicable for war using a new method. The dancing simulation is supposed to help with coordination, synchronicity, and kinesthesia. It's clearly worth doing from how many cadets stumble over their own feet attempting it.
Adora is one of those people. Catra isn't. A little extra training away from prying eyes can help.
(Or, why Adora and Catra knew how to dance at Princess Prom)

Notes

This fic is part of the Thank You She-ra event to celebrate She-ra before it leaves Netflix, written for the week one prompt: season one.
This is actually set pre-season one, but the inspo comes from Princess Prom in season one. I came up with this headcanon based on it for how they used dancing as training and I've been meaning to write a fic about it since 2020. Like usual, I'm using a fandom event to force me to write an idea I've been sitting on for a while.

See the end of the work for more notes

Chapter 1

Catra is the most agile cadet, not just in her squad, but in her entire class.

Of course she gets no credit for it. She's a magicat. It's natural, she's told. Her birth just gave her abilities as if she cheated for them. No one thinks that Kyle or Rogelio is more impressive in their lack of grace, but those who train for it and don't achieve as much, like Adora and Lonnie, get more praise than Catra even when she performs flawlessly.

When Catra tries harder than everyone else at something and doesn't get first, she doesn't get praise because that's reserved for top performers and she only deserves degradation for her shortcomings. When she tries hard and gets first, she doesn't get the same praise because it's reserved for those who committed the most and she somehow didn't put in the same effort as second best. She never wins. It makes her angry. Then she gets in trouble for lashing out, or talking back, or blowing something off. *She never wins*.

To say she isn't thrilled about the idea of dance lessons is an understatement. It's standard, a new way to teach body control, timing, and footwork to the clumsiest cadets. For some it's a lesson in *listening*, even. For her, it sounds like torture. She's going to hate it, she doesn't need it, and she already knows they're going to play the music too loud and yell at her for putting her arms in the wrong place even though that part of the training doesn't actually contribute to any combat skill. They'll find anything to criticize her for.

"Please tell me you'll be my partner. If I have to dance with Kyle someone is going to die, and I'm not letting it be me," Catra hisses in Adora's ear as they give the announcement to their entire cadet class. Adora giggles, glancing at her with a sparkle in her eye before she focuses on Cobalt reading off their final date

assignments. Whatever, hopefully that means yes. Adora always tries to pay attention when the adults are around.

Catra has learned that doesn't make a difference for *her*, so she doesn't bother.

--

Dancing is one thing. Memorizing dance moves is another. Catra is better at memorization than Adora, and better at body control while she's at it. She still feels awkward trying to follow the steps the instructor is insisting on teaching them for some reason. She feels a little better when other people fall performing the dip or scramble to hold up their partners, though, and *especially* when people stumble or step on their partner's shoes. That's one thing she and Adora never do. They're spaced out widely with holograms filling in the gaps. From other cadets' reactions, she thinks they shock you if you collide with them. She wouldn't know, she has successfully kept Adora from getting that far off so far, at least.

Adora is… having a bit more trouble than Catra, mostly because she's standing tall and stiff and can't seem to just relax and follow the – admittedly boring – music, acting like she's in line for inspection instead of moving fluidly. Her arm is supposed to be raised so she and Catra can cross hands, not so they can salute, but you wouldn't know it with how she's holding herself. It's making her miss music cues, and it's hard for Catra to cover for her when she's not the one *leading*.

Half of the pairs around them start twirling – the other half lagging as far behind as Adora – and Catra decides to take matters into her own hands, grabbing Adora's hand and spinning her away from her for herself.

When she pulls her back in so they're face-to-face, Adora's face is flushed with indignation, Catra is in the lead, and she might be grinning.

"Let me take point, you *clearly* need it," Catra purrs to her. Adora scowls and she pulls her wrist away, crossing theirs a bit aggressively as she stumbles back to stepping in time as they circle each other. Privately, Catra thinks there must be dances they could teach them that would be far better for increasing their kinesthesia or whatever they said, but with how many people are struggling with this one, maybe that wouldn't be a good idea. It would be nice to get the chance to show off, though.

It's not like she would get praised for it anyway. Somehow she would get made fun of for it in the end. Dancing would be embarrassing when not the bare minimum ordered by their supervisors, probably.

Adora stands so stiffly, it *is* like she's embarrassed, still dark in the face with a determined little scowl on her face as she glances down at her body too much, correcting the placement of her foot, or her elbow, or her own neck when she remembers she should be looking up. Catra knows her, though, and to her eye Adora almost looks anxious as she fails to catch a music queue on time again and she moves them forward a beat delayed.

This clearly isn't working, and Adora clearly isn't ready to let Catra lead. She's probably embarrassed to be seen needing a lead when she's supposed to be the big bad future Force Captain.

Whatever. Catra can work with this.

--

Adora has a tendency to reluctantly go along with whatever Catra wants and just complain about it.

"We're going to get caught. Someone's going to hear!" she protests even as she follows Catra up to the controls for the PA system of the empty simulation deck. Catra pokes around at the controls, eventually finding the cartridge slot.

When she pops it out it's unlabeled, but what are the odds they changed the program out in the middle of dance practice?

"Okay, would you rather fall on your face tomorrow when we'll have Force Captains observing? Octavia's going to be there, you know she'll take any chance to knock us, and then it'll be Shadow Weaver next," Catra reminds. The unit is only three days. That's not a lot of time to improve. Adora always takes every chance to improve. Adora isn't seriously protesting, anyway, or she wouldn't have let it get as far as Catra turning the sound system down to the lowest setting and plugging the cartridge back in.

She turns to an uncertain Adora with a grin, holding out her hand.

"Come on, Adora, dance with me. Live a little, improve a little, what's the downside?" Catra says. For some reason, Adora blushes, but she takes her hand and lets Catra lead her down to the middle of the deck, weaving between sweeping holographic pairs in weird dresses and suits.

--

Without someone yelling out form instructions and reminders to tuck in their elbows, Adora is a little worse.

She's also looser, more fluid, not nervous the way that she was under observation and thus *better* to the naked eye, even if not to the grading rubric. Catra stopped caring about those a long time ago, but she knows Adora still does.

“Let me lead. You can copy me to memorize it and then you can go back to dipping me,” Catra proposes. She knows she’ll never get away with leading in front of Shadow Weaver. Adora is their squad leader, it’s beneath her to let Catra be in charge even just of a dance.

She’s so sick of it. She wants to lead for once. Adora hesitates for only a moment before she offers Catra a smile.

“Oh, you think you’re so good you memorized both our parts?” Adora teases, but she steps closer and Catra feels her ears twitch as she raises her hand and Adora takes it. Catra scoffs, but it feels nice, warm, that Adora is letting her. Adora is the only one who matters that would let her. Kyle would, but it’s weaker to lead Kyle than it is to be led by Adora. At least then she’s worthy of sharing the spotlight that Shadow Weaver always casts on Adora.

“Please, they’re the same thing except I have to be better at it. The hardest part will be not letting you pull us to the floor,” Catra says as she waits for the music to hit the right note for them to begin moving. It’s a continual loop, but they need to start on beat. Adora rolls her eyes and misses the cue, hurrying to follow when Catra begins stepping.

“I can support my own weight if you’re too shrimpy to hold me up,” Adora says and Catra grabs her wrist so she can haul it near her, trying to bite it. Adora laughs as she pulls it away, but Catra doesn’t let go, so they end up twirling in the center of the floor.

Catra dips her at the end. She grins as Adora blinks up at her, surprised and blushing a little.

“Sorry, what was that?” Catra teases, leaning in dangerously close, but they’d hear the door opening before it would lift enough to be spotted like this.

“I’m supporting my own weight,” Adora protests, weakly. Catra shrugs and lets go.

Adora predictably falls to the floor, managing to catch herself but huffing as she stands.

"Maybe I shouldn't trust you to lead," she complains. Catra rolls her eyes and holds out her hand again.

"I'm doing you a favor. I'm *going* to get you able to lead by the morning – but I have to do it first," Catra says. Could she teach Adora without leading first? Maybe.

She wants to, though. Adora sighs, scrunching up her face, but she takes Catra's hand. Catra grins as she pulls them into position so they can cross their hands again. She can't think of it as *holding* hands, that's dangerous, and doesn't feel accurate with how loose the touch is. The sanctity of the rare moments where they actually get to do that needs to be preserved.

They're not going to get a lot of sleep, probably, but it's fun.

--

Catra thought Adora's problem was the pressure and embarrassment from how stiff she was.

It turns out that's only half of it. She's more relaxed with Catra, more willing to make mistakes, but all those mistakes add up to one thing.

"You can't really sense the rhythm, can you?" Catra asks as she once again moves – on time – a half second before Adora follows her. Adora huffs.

"I can hear it," she says, which is not at all what Catra was asking. Catra rolls her eyes.

"If you're following me, that's fine, but if you're leading, you need to start picking it up," Catra says. Adora whines.

"I know! But it's hard. Why can't they just use a metronome? It's not like we're training to *really* dance, we're only doing it to help with our other training," Adora complains. It's so funny seeing her be so bad at something and care so much. Usually when she's bad at something, she throws herself into training with the mindset she can master it. This time she doesn't seem to know how to even go about it.

"Maybe it's so we all know what to do when celebrating our victory at the end of the war," Catra says, and at least the corner of Adora's mouth twitches. Catra shifts her hand, pulling Adora in after she fell out of step. Adora blushes as Catra's hand lands on her hip. "You still won't have it by then, but I'll just do this and we can cover it up," Catra says, beginning to step back and forth in time. Adora huffs, but after a moment of stumbling, she manages to catch on, and then they're just swaying together, stepping left, then right, over and over so they slowly move across the floor just enough to stay in formation with the holograms. Oh. This is really… nice. Catra is blushing, now, but it's kind of like they're hugging even as they move back and forth, and Adora is really close, and her face is darkening at well. The position feels dangerous.

She never wants to leave it. She clears her throat.

"Let's just do this and you listen to the music as you follow me, okay? I'll keep us on rhythm so you can learn it, and then we can try the real dance again," Catra offers.

"Y- Yeah, okay," Adora agrees, and Catra can't ask why she's stuttering, can't even think about it. The slight blush on her cheeks is so tempting. Catra doesn't even know what she wants to do aside from get closer. She wants to nuzzle, press against her, brushes their cheeks together, their…

She tightens her hand on Adora's waist and focuses on the music, the steps falling in time, the subtle rise and fall of her breathing until it syncs up with the beat, and slowly Adora's does too. It's just the swell and crest of the music, Adora's chest brushing against hers on the inhales, and her warm body against Catra's. It's *just* that, but it feels like it's rewiring something in her brain. It feels like she's breathing for the first time. The first time since the last time they got to hold each other like this, anyway.

It doesn't happen often. There's no reason for them to. It's weak to seek the touch of another and dangerous to be caught with Adora's, specifically, but Catra *would* win a war for the chance to do this one more time, to be able to fully wrap her arm around Adora's waist and dance like it doesn't matter, to tip her forward until they both spill to the floor on top of each other this time, free because there's no more military hierarchy to fall in line for.

She feels the most free and the most trapped she has ever been in Adora's arms.

--

Adora must have really terrible rhythm, because it feels like they have been doing this forever and she hasn't given any hint of pulling away. Catra has her eyes closed now, purring a little in time with the music as they sway with the rhythm. She thinks they might have drifted closer together but she's not sure. It's just so peaceful, despite the ugly music in the background. She wonders if there's prettier music. The Horde probably wouldn't have it, anyway. They should steal some when they finally crush the princesses.

Catra slits her eyes open to check on their position relative to the holograms, redirecting them a little, and then drops her head on Adora's shoulder. It's so against the rules, but she's tired, and this

is nice, and it's making her *really* sleepy in a way that isn't accounted for by just the late hour. Adora sucks in a breath and suddenly Catra is awake because she's nervous, but she doesn't dare move and reveal that, which brings them to the stand-off of continuing to move back and forth at a steady pace. Why does something that feels so nice have to come with so much anxiety?

"Are you tired?" Adora murmurs to her, breaking the silence that has fallen around then since they started this slow dance. Catra breathes in, a subtle vibration to it from the purr she just can't shake in Adora's arms.

"Let's get you on rhythm first," Catra mumbles back, because she doesn't want this to stop.

Adora stops moving.

"I think I've got it. Let's try the dance again," she says, and then she lets Catra go. Catra's contented sleepiness is suddenly gone, but she's not awake – no, now she feels exhausted in a bad way. She takes in a deep breath to brace herself as she reluctantly steps to the appropriate distance and raises her arm.

She leads in time with the music. After so long swaying to it, Adora's steps follow it with much more ease than before. They're more in sync with each other, too, but they get to the part when Catra is supposed to dip her and she hesitates, not sure if she can do it this tired.

Adora's hand falls on her waist, dipping her back. Catra feels like something more than her center of gravity falls, and she makes no move to pick herself up until Adora pulls her back in, leaning forward straight into Adora's arms. Adora seems to think she's falling, quickly wrapping her arms around her.

"Come on, I think that's enough for tonight. We still have another day before the final and we need to be awake enough for the observation tomorrow," Adora says to her. Catra thinks about protesting, because it will buy her a few seconds in Adora's arms

as Adora convinces her it really is time, but she has already tried her luck too many times tonight.

"Okay," she agrees, and Adora steps back, but she puts a hand in Catra's – maybe to catch her if she really does stumble and fall asleep – and holds it as she leads her from the room.

They left the music on. It's funny, because Octavia yells at Cobalt about wearing out the cartridge when they come in for their dance practice the next day.

It's sad, because Adora does have it now, which means no more secret dance sessions.

--

Catra still thinks they would be better off with her leading them, but she doesn't bring it up or try it again. The extra practice pays off. It takes Adora a few minutes to find the rhythm again the next day, but then they're able to fall in line, and it takes her a few tries to master leading, but from the corner of Catra's eye, she thinks they might be one of the best pairs, Adora's stiffness dissipated with all the training. It's actually kind of fun, knowing they're doing well and hearing other people get yelled at as they step in time with each other, occasionally spinning together.

Okay, the fun part is when she spins back into Adora's arms, and how firm her arm is around Catra when she dips her, but the fun is *there* and she'll miss it when they move on to the next unit and go back to beating each other up. She misses it even in this unit, when they switch from the pair dances to incorporate moving between partners. Adora starts fumbling for a moment again, but she always corrects when she spins back to Catra, and they spend the majority of the dance together still. It's probably just because it's easier to grade that way, but Catra has to deal with Rogelio

being the one to lift her rather than Adora, and that would have been so *fun*. At least she still gets the dip.

It's fun until their final, when Shadow Weaver comes to observe them and take notes on who has the best footwork. Catra can't look like she's enjoying touching Adora, and she has to concentrate extra hard, because she knows the slightest delay will make her get a correction shouted. She also can't help Adora like she did before under the scrutiny, which means Adora has to be flawless. Adora clearly knows it too, because she's stiff again.

She has learned, though. Her first step is off, but her second is able to fall in line with Catra's, and their muscle memory takes over from there. Adora's stiffness might not look as good as Catra's natural fluidity, but she spins at the right time, she dips at the right time, and she pulls Catra back to her feet easily. The joy of it is just gone as they fall back into the cycle, repeating it and ignoring the other pairs around them, the way very few twirl on the same exact beat and it makes the entire room seem offbeat compared to them.

It doesn't matter. Shadow Weaver will probably decide that her protégé is the one setting the standard that everyone else should be following. Not a single command nor correction is issued. They aren't supposed to improve today – they're supposed to go long enough that Shadow Weaver has time to observe everyone's skill. Adora isn't spinning back to Catra off-beat when they part ways anymore, but she always seems like she has been thrown until their hands touch again. Catra counts the cycles in her head, one, two – someone yells at their partner in the distance as they step on their foot – three, four – two pairs collide into each other and snipe at each other even as they both go back to dancing – five, six – people are getting really out of sync, now – seven – Kyle falls flat on his ass during a dip despite his partner doing their best – eight-

"Enough," Shadow Weaver commands just as Adora spins Catra back into her arms again and everybody looks up. She's standing at the console and uses one long finger to shut off the music.

Catra realizes she's still holding Adora and hastily lets her go, Adora also seeming to realize and taking a step back as they both keep their gaze fixed on Shadow Weaver.

Her mask shouldn't let Catra know where her eyes are focused, but she swears it's on them.

"The standings will be posted after dinner. Those who have done well will receive grey ration bars," Shadow Weaver says, and then she turns away, likely to make those notes. Adora turns her head to Catra, grinning, and Catra smiles back. She's excited. She has only had brown bars for a while.

--

Even when Catra does well, she doesn't get rewarded for it. It comes too naturally to her.

Adora gets grey and Catra gets brown. Adora gets first and Catra gets *third*.

She shouldn't start a fight, but she's furious. All that time, all the training *she* gave Adora that she wouldn't have even made the leader board without, and Catra doesn't even get number *two* beside her?

"The leading partner naturally demonstrates more skill than the leader. Rogelio displayed a lot of it to adapt to his slower physiology *and* accommodate for his partners," Shadow Weaver says with cold disdain as Catra glares up at her beside the screen posted at the entry to the hall, tail lashing.

"*I* was accommodating for Adora. I taught her to lead, not Cobalt! She couldn't even time her steps without me," Catra hisses back.

"Catra…" Adora cautions behind her, placing a hand on her upper arm as Shadow Weaver narrows her eyes down at her, but Catra doesn't care.

"You will *not* steal credit from your superiors," Shadow Weaver orders in that tone of voice that can turn Catra's blood cold most days, but not today, not when she feels like she's burning with an anger that feels a lot like shame. She should have second, she should have *first*, but she never expected that.

She never expected third if Adora came first.

"Whatever, see if I help you next time. When you fall on your face, everyone will see," Catra scoffs to Adora, yanking her arm away and turning on her heal.

"Catra!" Shadow Weaver booms after her, and that voice says that running will actually be worth it, because she's going to get hurt if she lets herself get caught.

She takes off on all fours, hearing Adora scrambling to cool – or at least slow – Shadow Weaver down as Catra disappears down the hall, eyes as hot as her heart.

She forgot not to care – she forgot to never feel proud of something. Dancing felt special.

Special isn't allowed to exist in the Horde.

--

Adora finds her up at their lookout point. Catra doesn't acknowledge the sound of her climbing up except to ball up tighter, pressed against the railing with her head resting on the cold bar, her eyes closed because they sting from crying. She

hates crying. Having physical proof of your emotions is as bad an idea in the Horde as having them in the first place.

Adora stops moving for several long seconds when she climbs up. Catra ignores her. Adora walks over to where she's curled up. Catra ignores her.

Adora sits down next to her and Catra does her best to ignore how badly she wants to lean into her arms, but Adora doesn't do it first, and she's probably mad at Catra too.

"I told Shadow Weaver how much extra practice I needed," Adora eventually says. Catra's ears pin back. She wasn't expecting that. She was expecting Adora not to talk to her for a little while as retaliation for exposing her weakness.

Not that she's ever done that, but Catra has always been worried when that the day will come that Adora finally listens to Shadow Weaver and agrees that Catra is out of line. She certainly stepped out of it tonight.

"Did she tell you how dedicated that makes you and that you tried harder than me?" Catra mutters, bitterly. Adora doesn't answer. Catra scoffs. Obviously.

"She also scolded me on sneaking out at night," Adora adds in a joking tone and it does actually draw a bitter laugh out of Catra.

"Of course." She's probably in even more trouble now. Adora nudges her. Catra doesn't open her eyes or look at her. Adora scoots closer. Catra ignores her as Adora presses their shoulders together now.

"She raised your rank to number two," she says and Catra finally opens her eyes, mostly because she doesn't believe her. She turns to look at Adora.

She has a small smile on her face and a wrapped ration bar in her hand – a gray-wrapped bar. Catra feels her ears prick up, tail starting to sway against the floor with a soft *thump thump*.

"So how much trouble am I in?" Catra asks, because she doesn't trust it. Adora rolls her eyes and reaches out, balancing the ration bar on Catra's knees since they're tucked against her chest. She curls around them.

"You're not in trouble." She pauses. "Anymore," she amends and Catra snorts, finally unfurling so she can place the bar in her lap.

She's going to save it, hide it. They don't go bad. She inevitably will get in trouble and not get her proper rations as a result. Having this waiting for her, the best there is when they tried to take away even the worst, will be nice. It might be enough to stop her from having another outburst.

Once. There will always be more in the future. It will always be unfair, at least until they're leading themselves. Catra *did* show the ways she's a leader and responsible with this unit. That's why it hurt so much to have it thrown in her face.

Adora reaches up and ruffles her hair.

"You're welcome," she says, as if Catra said thanks. Catra scoffs, reaching up to bat at her hand, but she's smiling.

"*You're* welcome for teaching you how to dance," Catra corrects. Adora huffs – okay, so she is annoyed at Catra outing her – but she holds her hand out to Catra.

"Come on, it's going to be lights out soon. You want to find somewhere to stash that first, right?" Adora asks and Catra feels something warm in her heart and cold in her limbs.

Adora knows the same thing Catra does, but she cares. It's enough. It's the only reason she made it this far, the *real* reason she stayed up all night to teach her how to place her feet. She wasn't being a leader. She was being weak, if anything.

She'll be anything for Adora, because Adora is the only one who would be *something* for her. Catra looks at her hand.

She takes it, and she pulls herself to her feet, and she continues that movement straight into a spin until she's leaning back in Adora's arms just like the dance.

"If I can barely dance with music, I definitely can't do it up here," Adora says, amused. Catra chuckles, voice a little squeaky as she indulges herself in leaning back against Adora for just a moment, and then she unfurls from her with a sigh, ration bar tucked against her chest.

"You are a lot better now," Catra says, because she can't quite make herself say *sorry for insulting you in front of Shadow Weaver*. Adora looks at her for a long moment, and then she squeezes her hand.

"Yeah, I am," Adora acknowledges, taking back the credit that her work is owed before she steps back and leads Catra back off the platform.

Catra wishes they could dance again. She wishes they could do it to better music. She wishes they could hold each other again.

Maybe after the war – if that ever exists.

Chapter 2: After the War

Chapter Notes

> I know this was a one shot. But I changed my mind. I do this a lot. LOL actually a comment on the last chapter inspired this!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The real appeal of dancing for Catra was Adora, really. She looked forward to the dancing part of the plan at Princess Prom an unreasonable amount, went back to the simulation to brush up, even, almost *giggling* to herself at night picturing Adora's face when she grabbed her hand and took the lead from her.

She also sighed with too much contentment thinking of *before* she would take the lead, leaning back into Adora's arms and feeling her heartbeat again.

She basically refuses to breathe without it beating against her right now, so dancing doesn't exactly hold the same appeal to her, but they're bringing in a full band for a quick "welcome back to your recently un-captured castle" party for the residents before they all go back to work, so there is a source of music even a few hours before they open the doors, because the musicians have to practice, too. Catra didn't know that, but why Adora led her here makes sense as soon as she sees it.

"Come on, dance with me?" Adora asks, holding her hand out to her even though her other arm is already wrapped around Catra's waist. Catra glances down at it.

"We're supposed to be… somewhere," she says. She doesn't really know where. Adora's lips quirk.

"Yeah? Can you take us there?" Adora asks. Catra rolls her eyes, looking away with a huff.

“Can I lead this time?” Catra asks. Adora pauses.

“Yeah, whatever you want,” Adora promises, voice suddenly soft enough that Catra’s gaze snaps back to her. She expects something bad. Instead the expression on Adora’s face knocks the breath out of her chest.

It’s soft, too. So soft it feels sharp, dangerous enough to cut if she lets herself fall into it, but unlike the anxiety that surrounded their first embrace on the simulated dance floor, she now knows it’s safe to indulge in Adora’s touch, her love.

Catra puts her hand in Adora’s and then leads her to the center of the room.

--

“Does Bright Moon have better dances?” Catra asks as they fall into the old step work. Adora takes a moment to catch onto the beat like always, but she’s faster on the uptake than she used to be.

“Uh- Hm. I don’t know, actually. We didn’t party much, before. There were birthday parties and stuff, but not usually dancing like this,” Adora admits, sounding a little stumped, and thus disgruntled, because she hates not knowing something. If she had her way, a color-coded binder with handwritten instructions with full explanatory illustrations and diagrams would have popped into existence in her hand the moment Catra said that.

“Well, they have better music,” Catra decides, and then she spins Adora out from her. The best part comes next.

Adora spins back into her arms, leaning back against her chest. Catra breaks formation, wrapping her arms around Adora’s waist and sighing with relief, nuzzling against her neck.

“Who needs dancing?” she murmurs to her, lips brushing against Adora’s skin. Adora shivers.

“I don’t know, it seems pretty good to me right now,” she admits, voice a little breathy. Catra chuckles and tilts her head so her lips are against Adora’s ear instead.

“If we were alone, we could actually kiss,” she points out. Not that they refrain from it… pretty much ever, but they are being annoying in front of strangers just trying to do their job in the corner of the room right now. She *feels* what those words do to Adora’s heartrate, and the rhythm of her breathing, while she’s at it.

“I- *Yes*, but is in a little bit okay? I’ve kind of been picturing this for a long time. I want to enjoy it,” Adora says. Catra’s breath hitches.

She drops her arms from around Adora’s waist so she can turn her to face her, close enough that they’re almost chest-to-chest as Catra looks up at her.

“What do you mean?” she asks, too much breathless hope slipping in. Adora’s smile is a little shy, but in no way *little* as she looks at her and Catra feels so, so much at the beautiful sight.

“I really liked our dance when we were alone. I always wanted to do it again with you without people watching us. To just hold each other again,” Adora admits even though they fell asleep with all their limbs tangled and Adora’s cheek pressed into her shoulder last night.

Catra has had this moment happen a dozen times since coming to Bright Moon, but it happens again just as strong as the first and the *last*: her heartrate skips, her breath catches, and some line of tension in the net that has held her heart out of her chest so it can’t get hurt snaps as something distant but no less profound shifts, something she can’t even name, but it’s deep inside the

foundation at her soul, and if she keeps having moments like this, pretty soon she might be a brand new person.

She might be excited for Adora to meet that person. That person might not be afraid to do things because she can't be recognized for them. That person might not plan ways that she can hurt the people who hurt her because she already knows that won't make her feel better. That person might be who she used to be, before the war, and before the trauma, and before Shadow Weaver broke her, but after, after, *after* Adora touched her for the first time and made Catra's hers with the softest embrace.

Catra's left hand finds Adora's waist, and the right reaches for her hand, the exact same position they held in that quiet, private dance in each other's arms, breaking from the choreography entirely and just holding each other with a thin excuse apparently neither of them needed.

"I always wanted to do this with you after the war," Catra admits in a whisper, and to her surprise, she watches that same tiny, *monumental* shift happen behind Adora's eyes.

Adora pulls closer, and they're chest-to-chest, tighter than they were as teenagers, but it feels softer. Catra's skin isn't on fire like it was then, because she's starting to get used to Adora's touch considering they've hardly left arms-distance since the Heart. She felt like a live wire against Adora back then, it was so *exciting*.

Now she sinks into her embrace as she begins swaying them, but she doesn't bother with all the footwork. There are no holograms to avoid, just the two of them in the center of the floor, and they can slowly circle together without need to justify it, Adora leaning down to rest their foreheads together and Catra purring into the air heavy with Adora's breath. They can dance however they want to, now, and Catra wants to use it as an excuse to feel her body sync with Adora's, their breaths slowly lining up like they once did on an empty dance floor in the dead of night.

After the party tonight, there might not even be dancing. If there is… maybe they'll do this, too. Maybe they won't care who sees now. Maybe another thread will snap.

The net is already too loose to be doing anything now, it just puts on enough tension to make everything feel hard, but this… this feels easy.

Chapter End Notes

> I saw a comment that mentioned they'd get to dance together after the war and then I wrote all of this in like 30 minutes at is2g like 1am. Anyway I couldn't decide if including this in the fic kind of "cut" its impact but I didn't want to post it as its own fic since it's directly building on/referencing that one and I did like it when I read it in the morning so here you go okbye!!

End Notes

Petty kids with petty teenage feelings against the largest consequences in the world.

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